The belt-scroller: a genre study for Tales of Cloak & Claw

Study, 2026-10-14. Not a decision document: anything we settle goes to `docs/decisions.md`.

Where the project stood

- **Stage 1** (standee combat in one arena) built and waiting for its gate; the user has not played it yet.
- **Last tasks:** none under the new workflow. Written and queued: T001 tuning lab, T002 run log, A001 Mouse Fighter rig parts.
- **Being discussed:** the four design pillars (confirmed), League of Legends-style hero kits (parked for Stage 8), the stage plan through Stage 8.
- **Why this study:** the user wants to know the genre well before making the big calls (run structure, defence, progression, enemy roster).

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1. The short version

1. **The genre's core pleasure is crowd control.** You are outnumbered, and you win by positioning, by using enemies against each other and by turning a mob into a line you can hit. The best games give you few buttons but many ways to manage a crowd: throws, sweeps, knockdowns that bowl over others, weapons, a panic button.
2. **Fun comes from feel first, content second.** Hit-stop, knockback and sound sell a punch. Arcade classics had few animation frames and still felt heavy. (This is our Pillar 1.)
3. **Enemies are the real level design.** A stage is a sequence of enemy combinations. Each enemy type asks a different question (block me, chase me, dodge me, grab me), and mixing them is where depth comes from.
4. **Every great entry is remembered for one big idea:** Golden Axe's mounts and thieves, River City Ransom's shops and stat growth, Streets of Rage 4's health-for-power trade, Castle Crashers' levelling and pets, Absolum's roguelite runs.
5. **There are four broad structures:** a straight arcade run, a run with RPG growth, a roguelite, and an open map. They differ hugely in how much art and level content they need. For a small team making its own art, the roguelite and "arcade run with growth" structures give the most replay per image drawn.

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2. A short history

Origins (1984–1987): from one line to a floor

- **Kung-Fu Master** (Irem, 1984): one character walks one flat line punching waves of enemies. All the rhythm, none of the depth.
- **Renegade** (Technōs, 1986): you can move **up and down as well as left and right**, so enemies can surround you. This is the belt.

- **Double Dragon** (Technōs, 1987): two-player co-op, weapons dropped by enemies (bats, whips, knives), grabs and knees, and a bit of **friendly fire** that made co-op funny. It set the template almost everyone copied.

The arcade golden age (1989–1997)

- **Final Fight** (Capcom, 1989): huge sprites and big crowds. Three heroes with **different stat profiles** (Haggar slow and strong, Guy fast, Cody balanced). The **desperation move**: a spin attack that clears everyone around you but costs a little health. That one trade (safety now, cost later) shaped the genre for 30 years.
- **Golden Axe** (Sega, 1989): fantasy setting, **magic** powered by potion pots (more pots, bigger spell), **mounts** you knock riders off and steal, and **little thieves** who run in during breaks to steal or drop potions. Fantasy plus chaos plus a reason to chase things.
- **Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles** (Konami, 1989): four-player arcade co-op, bright characters, objects and enemies hurled at the screen. Proved the genre as a social party game.
- **The Simpsons** (Konami, 1991): same formula with team-up moves when two players stand close together.
- **Knights of the Round** (Capcom, 1991): heroes **level up** during a run, gaining armour and weapon upgrades: the first RPG growth in an arcade brawler.
- **Streets of Rage 1 and 2** (Sega, 1991–92): tight console design, specials that cost health, and a legendary club soundtrack. Part 2 is often called the best of the classic era.
- **Dungeons & Dragons: Tower of Doom / Shadow over Mystara** (Capcom, 1993–96): **classes** (fighter, cleric, elf, dwarf, thief, magic-user), spells, an item inventory, shops, **branching paths** and treasure. The deepest arcade brawlers ever made, and the closest ancestor of our game.
- **Guardian Heroes** (Treasure, 1996): three depth lanes you hop between, levelling, a branching story, and a huge amount of character.
- **Battle Circuit** (Capcom, 1997): fighting-game inputs and between-stage upgrade shopping.

The RPG branch (1989)

- **River City Ransom** (Technōs, NES, 1989): instead of a straight line, a **connected town** you roam. Money from beaten gangs, **shops and food that permanently raise stats**, **books that teach new moves**, and a password save. Small, funny and endlessly replayable. Our Pillar 3 comes from here.

Decline and the move to 3D (late 1990s–2000s)

Arcades faded, and brawling turned into 3D "character action" (Devil May Cry, God of War) and "musou" mass-battle games (Dynasty Warriors). The **2D belt-scroller nearly vanished in the West**, but survived in Korea as online games such as **Dungeon Fighter Online** (2005): classes with cooldown skill bars, passives and "awakening" ultimates (the League-style kit idea).

The indie and modern revival (2008–now)

- **Castle Crashers** (The Behemoth, 2008): cartoon art, **XP and four stats** to raise, unlockable weapons, **animal orb pets** that help you, a block button and an overworld node map. It revived the genre and showed **cartoon art plus RPG growth** can carry a whole game.
- **Scott Pilgrim vs. the World** (Ubisoft, 2010): River City Ransom-style shops and stats with superb pixel art.
- **Dragon's Crown** (Vanillaware, 2013): D&D-style classes, loot, skill trees, a dungeon-delving loop and a procedurally varied post-game dungeon.
- **River City Girls** (WayForward, 2019): modern River City Ransom with an open town, shops and equipment.

- **Streets of Rage 4** (Lizardcube / Guard Crush, 2020): **juggles and wall bounces** for long combos, and specials that cost health which you **earn back by keep hitting without getting hit**. Deep for experts, easy for beginners.
- **TMNT: Shredder's Revenge** (Tribute, 2022): six-player co-op, distinct move sets, a light levelling layer.
- **Absolum** (Guard Crush / Supamonks / Dotemu, 2025): the genre's biggest recent success. A **roguelite**: four classes, light and heavy attacks, mana-powered "Arcana" specials, **dodge/parry timing**, randomized passive boons ("Rituals") lost on death, branching paths and a hub between runs. Critics praised the crunchy combat; complaints were difficulty spikes and repetition.
- **On the horizon (2026):** a He-Man retro brawler (Bitmap Bureau), Scott Pilgrim EX (Tribute), Rushing Beat X (adding auto-combos, counters and a rage mode to a 1993 game), and Mayhem Brawler 2 (roguelite runs with branching paths and RPG upgrades). The roguelite-with-classes direction is clearly where the genre is heading.

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3. Why these games are fun

Pleasure	What delivers it
Power fantasy against a crowd	Knockdowns that bowl over others, throws into groups, wide sweeps, a panic button
Impact you can feel	Hit-stop, screen shake, knockback, sound, enemy reactions (the "crunch")
Readable cause and effect	Big silhouettes, telegraphed swings, clear "I got hit because I stood there"
Tourism	Every stage is a new place with its own gimmick: a moving train, an elevator, a boat, a burning village
Couch co-op chaos	Shared screen, combined attacks, fighting over the food on the floor
Short, complete sessions	A full game in 30 to 60 minutes; "one more go"
Mastery hidden in simplicity	Two buttons, but expert players juggle, crowd-herd and never get hit
Growth (RPG branch)	Watching numbers and moves improve; choices about what to buy or learn

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4. The combat levers

These are the dials every belt-scroller sets. Each says what it gives and what it costs.

4.1 Controls

- **Classic:** attack + jump (+ a special). Combos come from repeated presses; direction + attack gives variants (back attack, dash attack).
- **Modern:** light + heavy attacks, dash or dodge, special/skill buttons. Richer, but every button must earn its place, and keyboard and phone play suffer from too many.
- *Our state:* attack + jump. A third button (defence or special) is the most natural next step.

4.2 Combos, hitstun and juggling

- **Hitstun** (how long a hit enemy is helpless) decides how easy combos are. Long stun = easy flowing combos; short stun = tense trading.
- **Juggles** (hitting enemies in the air), **wall bounces** and **hitting downed enemies** extend combos for expert play (Streets of Rage 4). They add depth but also make enemies feel like punching bags if overdone.
- *Our state:* 3-hit combo with a knockdown finisher, jump slash. No juggles.

4.3 Grabs and throws

Walk into an enemy to grab, then throw them into others: the oldest crowd-control tool (Double Dragon, Final Fight). Throws turn enemies into weapons and reward positioning. They're cheap to show with standees: the thrown enemy just becomes a spinning projectile.

4.4 The defensive tool (the biggest design decision)

How the player escapes a bad spot defines a game's character:

Option	Example	Feel
Health-cost panic move	Final Fight, SoR	"Pay to escape." Forgiving, simple.
Recoverable-health special	Streets of Rage 4	Rewards aggression: keep hitting to earn the health back
Meter/potion magic	Golden Axe, Absolum (mana)	Save it for emergencies; big screen-clearing moments
Block	Castle Crashers	Safe and readable; can be passive
Dodge/roll	Many modern	Mobile; risks making positioning trivial
Parry (timed block)	Absolum, Rushing Beat X	Skillful and exciting; needs clear telegraphs (which our rats already have)

Our Mouse Fighter carries a **shield**, so a block-that-becomes-a-parry-when-timed fits the character, honours Pillar 2 (fair) and makes hits exciting (Pillar 1: a parry is a big hit-stop moment).

4.5 Weapons and the floor

Dropped weapons (Double Dragon knives, Final Fight pipes), breakable barrels hiding **food** (the classic "roast chicken in a barrel") and throwable objects make arenas into toolboxes. Cheap to add, big variety.

4.6 Enemy design (where depth really lives)

Classic archetypes, each asking the player a question:

Archetype	The question it asks	Classic example
Grunt	"Can you handle numbers?"	Final Fight's thugs
Rusher / charger	"Can you sidestep?"	Dashing enemies, bulls
Ranged	"Will you close the distance?"	Knife throwers, archers
Shielded / armoured front	"Can you get behind me or break my guard?"	Riot police, knights
Heavy (super armour)	"Will you stop mashing?"	Andore, fat bruisers
Grabber	"Will you keep your distance?"	Wrestlers
Hit-and-run / evasive	"Can you corner me?"	Ninjas, acrobats
Flyer / jumper	"Can you hit up?"	Bats, birds
Area denial	"Can you move under pressure?"	Fire, poison puddles
Thief / bonus runner	"Will you chase?"	Golden Axe thieves
Reviver / necromancer	"Who do you kill first?"	Priests, summoners

- **Fairness tools:** attack tokens (only one or two enemies attack at once), long telegraphs, enemies that circle instead of all piling in. *We already do this (Pillar 2).*
- **Bosses:** a pattern to learn plus minions, health in layers, and often one rule-breaking trick (Golden Axe's Death Adder, a boss that blocks, a boss that steals).

4.7 Juice

Hit-stop, shake, flashes, sparks, damage numbers, knockback distance, slow motion on the final KO, and sound. Arcade games tuned these obsessively. *We have most of these; sound comes in Stage 7.*

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5. The map and structure levers

Structure	Example	Content cost	Replay	Session fit (30–60 min)
Linear arcade run with locked "clear this group" arenas	Final Fight, SoR	Medium: every stage hand-made	Low to medium (score, characters)	Excellent
Arcade run + branching paths	D&D, Guardian Heroes	Higher: more stages	Medium	Excellent
Overworld node map (pick next stage)	Castle Crashers	Medium	Medium	Good (save between)
Open connected town	River City Ransom, River City Girls	High: big map, backtracking	Medium to high	Saves needed
Roguelite runs (random boons, branching map, hub, meta-unlocks)	Absolum, Mayhem Brawler 2	**Low per hour of play**: content is recombined	High	Excellent if a run is 30–60 min

Stage set pieces do a lot of work cheaply: a moving boat or cart (scrolling background), an elevator (enemies arriving from above), a collapsing floor, hazards (water edges, pits, conveyor belts), foreground props that hide enemies, weather.

6. Progression: the RPG dial

From none to deep: 1. **None** (Final Fight): every run the same; mastery is the progression. 2. **In-run levelling** (Knights of the Round, D&D): grow during a run, reset after. 3. **Persistent stats and shops** (River City Ransom, Castle Crashers): food and purchases raise stats permanently; books or levels unlock moves. 4. **Loot and skill trees** (Dragon's Crown, Dungeon Fighter): equipment, class trees. Deep, but number-heavy (watch our "no heavy bookkeeping" taste). 5. **Roguelite boons + meta-progression** (Absolum): random passive upgrades each run, lost on death, plus slow permanent unlocks between runs. 6. **Cooldown skill kits** (Dungeon Fighter Online, the League model): passive + abilities + ultimate per hero. Strong identity per character; more buttons.

Characters and differentiation run on the same dial: stat profiles (Final Fight's three), full classes (D&D's six), or kits (DFO / League).

7. What made the greats different

Game	Remembered for	Lesson for us
Double Dragon	Weapons, grabs, co-op	The floor is a toolbox
Final Fight	Big crowds, desperation move	A panic button with a cost
Golden Axe	Mounts, magic pots, thieves	Fantasy chaos and things worth chasing
River City Ransom	Shops, food stats, learnable moves	Growth that feels personal and funny
D&D Shadow over Mystara	Classes, spells, inventory, branches	Depth fits in a 45-minute run
Guardian Heroes	Lanes, levelling, branching story	Ambition, character
Castle Crashers	Cartoon art, XP, pets	Cartoon art + light RPG can carry a game
Streets of Rage 4	Juggles, recoverable-health specials	Reward aggression, keep it readable
Dungeon Fighter Online	Cooldown kits, awakenings	Heroes as distinct kits
Absolum	Roguelite runs, parry, boons	Replay from recombination, not more art

8. Directions we could take

A. Pure arcade run. Five or six hand-made stages, 30–45 minutes, score and lives. Cheapest to design, but needs the most stage art per hour of play and has the least "grow" (weak on Pillar 3).

B. Arcade run + River City Ransom growth (the current plan). Fixed stages; coins and food raise stats during the run; a shop between stages; learnable moves. Strong on Pillars 1–3. Replay is moderate.

C. Roguelite with fixed stages. Hand-made stages linked by a branching path map; each clear offers a choice of boons (a passive, a move upgrade, a stat); death ends the run; a hub between runs unlocks new boons and heroes. Most replay per piece of art (Pillar 4), strong growth inside each run (Pillar 3), natural 30–60 minute runs. Risk: repetition (Absolum's critics) and balancing boons (our bot runs help).

D. Open connected world (River City Ransom proper). Charming, but the most art and map work, plus saves and backtracking. Highest risk for us.

Lead's suggestion (for discussion, not decided): B growing into C. Build B first because it's what Stages 4–6 already plan. Then, if runs feel samey, add a branching path map and boon choices on top. That's a small step from B and it multiplies replay without new art. Keep League-style kits for when there's a second hero (Stage 8).

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9. Ideas that fit Tales of Cloak & Claw

These use art we already have (the art bible) or that is easy to make. All are proposals.

Combat

- **Shield parry for Mouse Fighter.** Hold to block (chip damage), tap just before a hit to parry: a big flash, hit-stop and the attacker staggered. Our rats' yellow windup flash already gives the timing cue.
- **Throws.** Grab a stunned rat and fling it into the others; the thrown body bowls them over. Cheap with standees: a spinning cutout.
- **Size matters.** In this world sizes are compressed but real: a mouse is about three-quarters of a rat's height. Small heroes could slide under high swings; big enemies can't be thrown, only staggered.
- **Food from the art bible.** Berry Pie and Cheese Wedge from broken crates heal and, River City Ransom style, give small permanent boosts. A Health Potion restores; a Mana Potion fills a special meter.
- **Panic move with a cost.** A shield-spin that clears a circle for a slice of health, regained by hitting without being hit (the Streets of Rage 4 rule): forgiving, and it rewards aggression.

Enemies (all from the art bible)

Enemy	Role	Question it asks
Rat Raider	Grunt	Numbers
Rat Archer	Ranged, retreats when approached	Close the distance
Stoat Duelist	Parries frontal hits; must be thrown, hit from behind or broken by a finisher	Positioning
Shield Beetle	Armoured front, charges in a straight line	Sidestep, then hit its back
Acidspitter Beetle	Leaves acid puddles	Move under pressure
Cavern Spider	Drops from above; webs slow you	Watch the shadows
Cave Bat	Flies above standing height	Jump attacks
Marsh Serpent	Lunges from the edge of the floor (water)	Don't hug the edge
Skeletal Mouse	Gets back up unless finished with a finisher	Who to focus
Bramble Brute	Boss: super armour, thorn bursts, summons	Pattern + adds

Golden Axe-style chaos

- **Mounts:** knock the rider off a **Shield Beetle** and ride it: a charging, armoured mount for a short while.
- **Thieves:** a tiny pickpocket scurries through between waves carrying a **Coin Purse** or potion; catch it for the loot (Golden Axe's thieves).

- **Treasure Chest** at the end of a stage: bonus coins, or a choice of boons (if we go roguelite).

Stages (the three environments we have)

- **Harbor Market:** crates and barrels to break, hanging cargo nets, knock enemies off the dock into the water (instant KO, a Golden Axe-style ring-out).
- **Living Cavern Settlement:** dim light with glowing crystals, spiders dropping from above, mushroom platforms.
- **Woodland Aqueduct:** waterfalls and ruins, vines, a moving-raft section along the channel.

Heroes later (Stage 8), as League-style kits

The five hero images (Mouse Fighter, Badger Guardian, Rabbit Mage, Fox Rogue, Squirrel Ranger) map neatly onto the classic five: balanced fighter, heavy tank, caster, fast rogue, ranged. Each could have a passive, three cooldown abilities and an ultimate, for example Badger Guardian's passive: "can't be knocked down while swinging".

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10. Questions this raises for the user

1. Run structure: **B**, **C**, or B-then-C?
2. Defensive tool: shield block/parry, dodge, or a health-cost panic move (or two of these)?
3. Grabs and throws: yes or no?
4. Breakable crates with food and floor weapons: yes or no?
5. How combo-heavy: keep simple 3-hit combos, or add juggles for expert play?
6. Death: lives and continues (arcade), or a run ends on death (roguelite)?

None of these is urgent before the Stage 1 gate. The gate answer ("is hitting rats fun?") comes first.

Sources

- Final fight(s): The 25 best beat-'em-up games (AV Club)
- Absolum (Wikipedia)
- Upcoming Beat 'Em Ups in 2026 (The Outerhaven)
- Best belt scroller video games of all time (Glitchwave)
- Other history and design detail: the lead's general knowledge of the genre; release years given to the best of that knowledge.